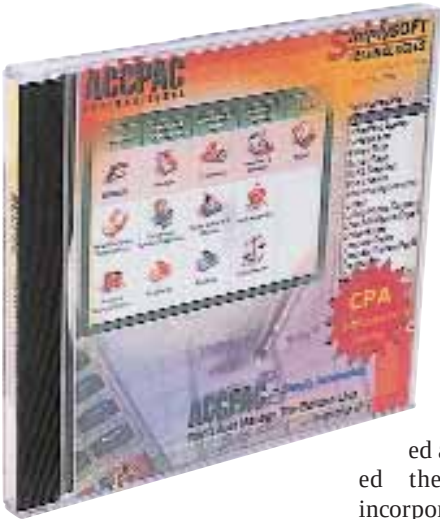




home office) users to medium and large enterprises.

This comparison test focuses on software created for the SoHo and small business segment. While Tally has always been a hot favourite of this segment, the past year has seen competition heating up with newer and better accounting software being launched, offering you more choices.

TEST PROCESS

To determine the overall performance of the accounting software, we evaluated a range of characteristics. These included the type of features the software incorporated, whether it offered value for money and whether it provided adequate help for a person to be able to work with it smoothly and without hassles.

Features, rather than technical specifications, form the core of a test such as this. We made a note of features such as inventory control, management information systems, multilingual support and security, and gave points for each of them to help us compare the products.

Cost is an important consideration. A product may be cheaper but may have only a single user license, which would be beneficial for a home user, but not for a SoHo user who has more than one computer. The software should be able to balance efficiency and features with a suitable price.

Features

The packages we tested contained a host of features, from a simple data entry screen that even a novice can understand to printing MIS reports that only top managers and CFOs require to make important business decisions.

Some of the features we gave more weightage to were inventory control, security, support for graphics in the form of graphs and charts and MIS support for accounting as well as for inventory.

Out of the packages we tested, only two were DOS-based. The rest were 32-bit applications running on MS Windows with a graphical user interface.

A convenient feature for new users is templates. FACT, Tally and Wings, all have good templates. Simply Accounting even has a template for creating and selecting a type of company, where you get to choose from at least 50 different types of businesses. The DOS-based packages lacked this feature.

Document designing is another feature of interest, because not all default reports and documents will suit your requirements. This

End-user Talk

We talked to several people who have used all kinds of accounting software on the job and found that many big companies prefer to use Oracle as their main database and accounting software because it allows them to do live updating of accounts and calculations with ease. Others told us that their companies used custom-made software to satisfy their needs. However, there are others, such as JM Waghela, who have been using accounting software such as Tally since a long time. Tally has been a long-time favourite with the accountancy community. People like using it because of its simple interface, and also because they are so familiar with all its aspects by now.

Although old habits die hard, we decided to introduce Waghela to some other accounting software. He found Wings 2000 Pro really interesting and easy to use. So much so that when we asked him which one he preferred, he picked Wings 2000 Pro!

feature was well-supported by DOS-based applications like ACE and Easy Accounting. But they were no match for Windows-based packages such as Simply Accounting, which comes with a Crystal Report writer that gives users complete freedom to create and design reports of their choice.

Regarding MIS reports, most of the packages tested provided a basic level of reporting such as accounts receivable/payable, cash/bank book, and ageing analysis of debtors/creditors/stocks. Tally has the distinction of providing the maximum number of financial reports. It gives users the option to use ratio analysis to determine, at any point, the company's working capital, operating cost, return on investment, return on working capital, etc. Simply Accounting stands out because of its ability to present reports graphically as well.

Like housekeeping is important in every aspect of life, so it is with these packages. A lot of data input takes place and maintaining that data in a healthy format is essential. It is important that the software allows you to back up data not only on floppy disks, but on other available media as well. And if the package can support export and import of data, that is a definite plus point.

Once again, Account 21, Tally, FACT and Wings scored over the others. Account 21 even has a proprietary explorer that allows users to view complete details at a glance, and even make changes if required. While Simply Accounting does allow you to take backups on

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